

512×342 PIXELS

THE RESOLUTION OF THE SCREEN
OF THE FIRST MACINTOSH COMPUTER


A worker on Apple's assembly line in Fremont, California checks and cleans a Macintosh computer.

FOLLOWING ON FROM THEIR SUCCESS with the Apple Lisa computer the previous year, Apple Computer Inc. launched a **groundbreaking new personal computer**: the Macintosh. Easy to use, with a modern design, and a high-profile advertising campaign, the Macintosh was aimed at breaking the growing dominance of IBM-compatible computers (see 1981). The following year, Microsoft would launch the Windows operating system, which gave users of IBM-compatibles

a graphical user interface, strengthening that dominance.

In February, American astronauts **Bruce McCandless** and **Robert Stewart** made the **first ever untethered spacewalk**. They were strapped into Manned Maneuvering Units (MMUs), which could move and orient in space thanks to 24 small retro rockets that emitted jets of nitrogen gas. McCandless

ventured nearly 328 ft (100 m) away from the spacecraft.

US secretary of Health and Human Services, Margaret Heckler, announced that American virologist **Robert Gallo** (b.1937) had **discovered the probable cause of**

“ **BEGINNING WITH A SINGLE MOLECULE OF... DNA, THE PCR CAN GENERATE 100 BILLION SIMILAR MOLECULES IN AN AFTERNOON.** ”

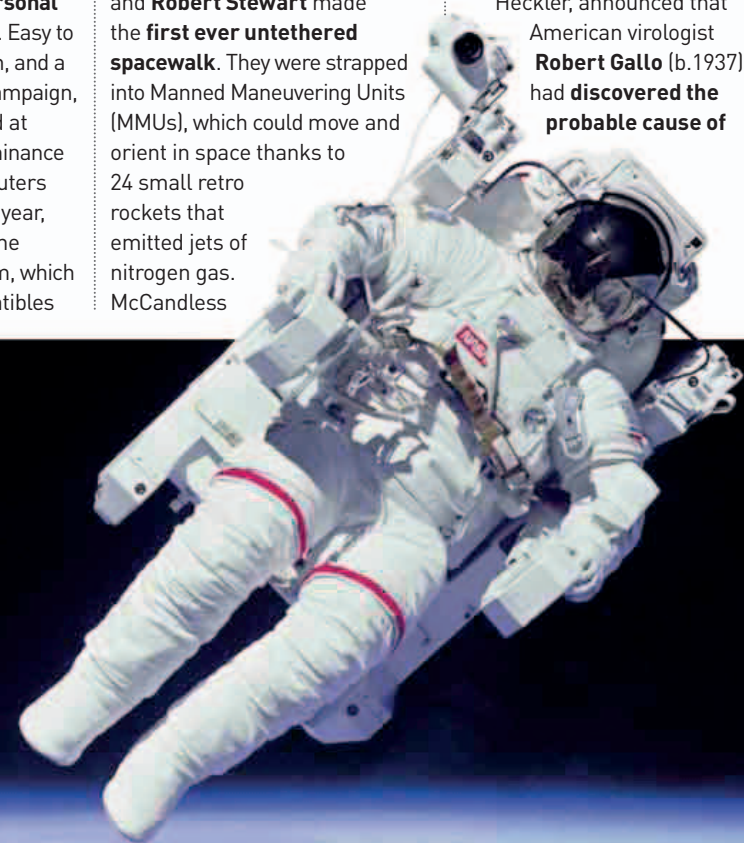
Kary Mullis, American biochemist, in *Scientific American*, 1990

AIDS (see 1982). Gallo had been collaborating with a team in France, led by French virologist Luc Montagnier (b.1932), who had also discovered a new virus that seemed to be related to AIDS. In June, Gallo and Montagnier

announced that the two new viruses were one and the same; the virus eventually gained its name, human immunodeficiency virus (HIV), in 1986.

This year, two independent teams of geneticists reported the same discovery—the genetic code in the DNA of the fruit fly (*Drosophila melanogaster*) that **control the development** of the insect's **major anatomical features**. These so-called homeobox sequences code for proteins that **switch other genes on or off** during the insect's embryonic stage. Homeobox genes have since been found in nearly all types of living organism, from yeasts to humans.

In September, British geneticist **Alec Jeffreys** (b.1950) developed DNA profiling—a tool that can be used to **identify individuals from samples containing their**



January 24 Apple Computer Inc.'s CEO Steve Jobs introduces the company's first **Macintosh computer**

February 7 Bruce McCandless II makes the **first untethered spacewalk**, outside the Space Shuttle Challenger

April 23 Scientists present their discovery of **virus responsible for AIDS**: the human immunodeficiency virus (HIV)

July Scientists at Indiana University, USA, report their discovery of **homeobox sequences**

25 July Soviet cosmonaut Svetlana Savitskaya becomes the **first woman to walk in space**

March Scientists at the University of Basel, Switzerland, report their discovery of **homeobox sequences—DNA that determines an organism's anatomical development**

June Kary Mullis presents the **polymerase chain reaction**, at a meeting of the biotechnology firm Cetus Corporation

10 September Alec Jeffreys develops **DNA profiling**

Untethered space walk

American astronaut Bruce McCandless II became the world's first human satellite, when he performed the untethered spacewalk, in February.